



Quick work: Manel Kape (right) knocked out former title challenger Brandon Royval (left) in the third minute of the first round during their flyweight clash.

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Undefeated UFC lightweight champion Ilia Topuria is temporarily stepping away from defending his title, not because of injury, but to confront an alleged extortion attempt, according to a statement he released on Monday via *Instagram*.

The 28-year-old Georgian fighter (17-0) will be absent from the upcoming UFC 324 event on January 24, which will feature an interim lightweight championship bout between Justin Gaethje and Paddy Pimblett in Paradise, Nevada.

Topuria said the decision to step away was difficult but necessary to address circumstances threatening his personal integrity, family and reputation. He claims he has been under severe pressure recently, including threats to circulate false allegations of domestic abuse unless he met certain financial demands. Topuria firmly denies the allegations as 'entirely unfounded'.

Topuria also said he has carefully preserved and documented all relevant evidence, including audio recordings, written communications, witness statements and video material, to combat the allegations and threats he has faced. This body of evidence has been submitted to judicial authorities as part of legal action against the alleged

perpetrators.

The legal claims he is pursuing include attempted extortion, falsification of evidence, misappropriation of funds and personal property, and multiple threats.

Topuria has been the reigning lightweight champion since his knockout victory over Alexander Volkanovski in February 2024 and has since defended the title twice, both by knockout. He affirmed that he will return to the cage once this matter has been fully resolved.

Short and sweet

The final UFC event of 2025 featured a decisive flyweight victory, as Manel Kape knocked out former title challenger Brandon Royval in the third minute of the first round. The win was Kape's eighth in his last nine bouts and strengthened his claim for a shot at new champion Joshua Van.

The bout was evenly poised until Kape landed a decisive right hook, leading to a swift stoppage. Kape's career started rough in the UFC with losses to Alexandre Pantoja and Matheus Nicolau, but he has since gone on a tear, winning three straight fights by finish.

His recent dominance complicates the flyweight division for Van, with contenders Tatsuro Taira and former champion Pantoja — who is due an immediate rematch once healthy — also in the title mix.



Did you know?

Veteran Conor McGregor made one of the most significant impacts on the lightweight division despite never defending the title.

After winning the interim belt against Chad Mendes, McGregor faced dominant champion Jose Aldo at UFC 194.

In one of the most famous moments in combat sports, McGregor ended Aldo's five-year reign with a lightning-fast left hand, winning the undisputed title via knockout in just 13 seconds — the fastest finish in a UFC title fight across all weight classes.

McGregor was later stripped of the belt due to inactivity after immediately moving up to lightweight, where he became the first simultaneous two-division champion in UFC history.